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Frege's Identity Puzzle: A Possible Solution

The *puzzle of identity* is a philosophical puzzle, or problem rather, in which many philosophers of language have uniquely attempted to solve. For I intend to highlight a solution, though I must first showcase the problem. Below are a pair of identity sentences involving co-referential terms – terms that both refer to the same object:

(a) *Mike Tyson is Mike Tyson.*

(b) *Mike Tyson is the baddest man on the planet.*

Sentence (a) doesn't tell us anything intelligent really. No one would question if Mike Tyson is Mike Tyson (perhaps in a state of existential crisis, he himself might). So the named object is simply the named object. Yet, sentence (b) tells us something more, perhaps new, about the object. This stumped not only Frege who attempted to solve the puzzle through his two-layered theory of *sense and reference*, but Russell enacted descriptivism, through the use of *definite descriptions*, to solve the puzzle. This was followed by Kripke, who offered persuasive

objections against descriptivism, providing instead a “direct reference” view of how names refer in regards to something now known as *the causal theory of reference* –though we will see that Kripke never established it himself as a legitimate theory. Through a Grice-inspired analysis of *assertions* of identity sentences, Stalnaker claims his findings are in line with those of Kripke. First, I will show how the attempts made by Frege, Russell, and Kripke, ultimately leave the *puzzle of identity* unsolved; and then I will explicate Stalnaker’s findings to show that his ‘analysis’ not only provides a solution to the puzzle, but it’s in support of Kripke’s direct reference view of how names refer.

Do names and descriptions refer to objects in the same way? Put another way, does the description of a given proper name, mean that name in which it is in-fact referring to? Someone may be quick to answer ‘yes’. It seems that we do not always use the name of an object when referring to it – we sometimes use a description to sort of *jazz things up a bit*, and from this, we assume that our audience will understand the given reference. Russell holds a different position regarding how names refer. He states that “denoting phrases never have any meaning in themselves, but that every proposition in whose verbal expression they occur has a meaning” (*Russell, OD 480*). So, Russell doesn’t believe that a description holds any weight – not until it is attached to some object and then expressed. He highlights that a description is more like that of a quantifier, e.g., *some* parents; *all* animals; *three* trees, for example – *some* (vague) quantity of an object is being expressed. It should be noted that the quantifier employed by Russell is fashioned in such a way as to fit one object exactly. Let’s focus our attention back to sentence (b) from above. Since definite descriptions can be replaced with quantifiers, Russell argues that the following sentence form is more appropriately expressed:

“Some x is the baddest man on the planet, and no other x is the baddest man on the planet, and x is Mike Tyson.”

Obviously, sentence (a) can be put through this same rigorous framework of Russell's, yet it's unnecessary. What Russell's rendering of sentence (b) seems to tell the reader in plain English is this: *There is one person that is the baddest man on the planet and that person is Mike Tyson*. So, this framework seems to highlight that the given description refers (denotes) to the given name; and not that the description *is* in-fact the name. Russell also claimed that proper names are often disguised as definite descriptions; this is known as the *Name Claim*; and this can lead to the understanding that said definite description literally means the given name. If this were true, that is to say, if the *baddest man on the planet* were to literally mean *Mike Tyson*, then we would be forced to deal with a statement like that of sentence (a) – *Mike Tyson is Mike Tyson* – a rather useless statement. Compare this with Russell's evaluation of *Scott is the author of Waverley*, and how he argues that *the author of Waverley* doesn't truly mean (equal) *Scott*, though his Russellian framework reveals that someone is *the author of Waverley* and this 'someone' is *Scott* – in particular *Walter Scott*. Russell supports this further by saying, “when it is said that Scott is the author of Waverley, we are not stating that these are two names for one man” (*Russell, 126*) Russell emphasizes that Scott needed to actually write Waverly in order to become the author, which he did; otherwise this would imply that people called Scott the ‘author of Waverley’ before he wrote *Waverly* (perhaps but unlikely). From this we can surmise that Mike Tyson has actually done certain things that eventually led to him earning the title of *baddest man on the planet*, which he has.

So then it seems that Russell was correct in stating, “an object is “known by description” when we know that it *is* “the so-and-so”, i.e., when we know that there is one object, and no more having a certain property” (*Russell, 113*). And regarding how “we are acquainted with an object which is the so-and-so” (*Russell, 114*), Russell has us consider this:

“We know the so-and-so exists, but we may know the so-and-so exists when we are not acquainted with any object which we know to be the so-and-so” (*Russell, 114*)”.

So, (I exhaust), even though I do not know Mike Tyson – we are not acquainted – I know that there is a person who in-fact has this name. “We know that there is an object answering to a definite description though we are not acquainted with any such object” (*Russell, 113*), as Russell states. So, between the *Name Claim* argument and his employment of definite descriptions, he seems to provide us with a solution to the *puzzle of identity*. A name, perhaps hidden behind the use of a definite description, doesn’t literally mean the definite description denoting it, as it may seem on the surface, but rather, there happens to be one object that in-fact has the name and fits the description, that is the phrase denoting it. This avoids the whole “Scott is Scott” nonsense, and gives to us instead a denoting phrase that *implicates* (thank you Grice) the object has actually done something to earn them the description.

Now I would like to contrast Russell’s view using definite descriptions to solve the puzzle, with that of Frege’s view regarding *sense*. For Frege, meaning has two layers, the first being *reference* and the second being *sense*. Now I will explain how Frege would apply this view to the set of sentences above. For he, like Russell, believed that sentence (a) doesn’t express

anything satisfying, nor interesting to the reader, yet he seems most curious with a sentence like sentence (b). I have restated the sentences below:

(a) *Mike Tyson is Mike Tyson.*

(b) *Mike Tyson is the baddest man on the planet.*

Frege also believes that the definite description given to the name is not literally the meaning of the name, otherwise, much like in our case with Russell, we would be guilty of turning sentence (b) into sentence (a), so then we would again have two, very plain statements, both expressing the same thing. So then how does Frege solve this problem, and how is it different from Russell? Recall that for Russell, it was introducing quantifiers in place of definite descriptions to show that a denoting phrase doesn't literally mean the name it is referring to, but rather that there is some object that has the given name and fits the given description. It's complicated, but it makes sense. In an attempt to put it plainly, Frege would say that the definite description, *the baddest man on the planet* is a *sense* in which the phrase is referring to some object – a person named Mike Tyson. So the phrase isn't actually the meaning of the name. As we say in English, 'in every sense of the matter' – 'every sense' can be thought of as all of the different ways to express 'the matter' – the *referent* as Frege called it; and that's just it; 'every sense' has to share the same referent, otherwise they cannot be considered as a sense of the referent. Compare this to the number of protons in atoms: a Helium atom, for example, must have two protons; any more or any less, and it is no longer Helium. I will introduce a third sentence – sentence (c) – just to make things clear:

(c) *Mike Tyson is Kid Dynamite.*

Based on what we just learned, Mike Tyson doesn't literally mean Kid Dynamite, but rather Kid Dynamite is a *sense* of the referent Mike Tyson. So too is the phrase *the baddest man on the planet*, a *sense* that shares Mike Tyson as a referent. To refer to Mike Tyson as *the Louisville Lip* would be incorrect, as the true referent for that *sense* is Muhhamd Ali.

Regarding sentences with the form of (b) and (c), let us consider a few potential outcomes:

1. It may be the case that sentences (b) and (c) tell the reader nothing new
2. Consider someone shaking hands with a person at a party who they were introduced to as *Kid Dynamite*. When asked later if they have heard of Mike Tyson, the person replies "yes I have heard of him." It is then revealed to the person that who they shook hands with earlier was in-fact Mike Tyson i.e., Kid Dynamite. The person (who would be in shock I assume) didn't know Kid Dynamite, yet they were (somewhat) aware of the person, Mike Tyson (maybe they heard about him on the radio). Yet, now they have empirical evidence that Mike Tyson is Kid Dynamite.
3. Consider an alternate version of the prior example, where the individual is aware of who Mike Tyson is, and what he looks like, prior to them being introduced, yet the individual is unaware that Mike Tyson is also known as the *baddest man on the planet*, or that he wore the name *Kid Dynamite* when he was younger. Perhaps the individual had heard these descriptions before, so that when they were introduced to Mike Tyson, but were given a 'different name', a bit of confusion lingered until they realized that there are

different ways (senses) that people refer to Mike Tyson; some of which they have heard before, but again, now they have empirical evidence that this is the same person.

Kripke gives two objections to show that descriptivism still leaves the identity puzzle unanswered. The first argument (objection) is known as the *Modal Argument*. As Lycan states, “questions about possibility and necessity are known as *modal* questions” (Lycan, 39). So then it would seem that what Kripke is attempting to address is that descriptivism implies “possibility” and “necessity”, which can lead to sentences that seem to be true, to actually be false – or more appropriately – not *necessarily true*. If someone refers to “Siddhartha Gautama” as “the Buddha”, is this statement true? Figuring that this is the name of the Buddha, how could the statement be false? Well, Kripke would argue that it isn’t a necessary truth that Siddhartha Gautama is the Buddha, for we can imagine quite easily, him never wandering outside his palace; never being exposed to pain and suffering; and never mastering meditation. So therefore, even though the expressed statement regarding “the Buddha” is true, it is not necessarily true. This is something that descriptivism doesn’t seem to address.

The second argument that Kripke gives is a work of fiction that orbits around Gödel’s Incompleteness Theorem (the theorem itself is of no importance here). Lycan tells us, “in Kripke’s fiction” (Lycan, 40), an established proof was made by a student of Gödel’s, “a man named Schimdt, who died mysteriously without publishing it” (Lycan, 40). After this event, Gödel evaluated the proof and published it using his own name. “Now most people know Gödel, if at all, as the man who proved the Incompleteness Theorem” (Lycan, 40), yet the proof was made by Schimdt. So there are two names of people that have solved the Incompleteness Theorem. Would it then be correct for us to say that Gödel is Schimdt, since we refer to Gödel as

the individual that solved the theorem, but who really solved the theorem was Schmidt? No, this is preposterous! In natural language, we would simply say that Gödel stole and published Schimdt's proof after Schimdt died. Therefore, when someone says that it was Gödel who proved the Incompleteness Theorem, "they are speaking falsely, however well justified they may be in their belief" (*Lycan, 40*). So lies another problem for descriptivism.

So it should be clear by now that Kripke objects "to the Name Claim and to description semantics" (*Lycan, 53*) and this "will also translate into objections to the Description Theory of referring" (*Lycan, 53*). In response to descriptivism, Kripke offers what is known as "the Causal-Historical Theory of referring" (*Lycan, 55*), which I will now attempt to explain. Let us consider some random baby that is assigned a name by their parents. This name is then discussed with friends and family of the parents and eventually "through various sorts of talk the name is spread from link to link as if by a chain" (*Lycan, 53*). Let's say the baby was given the name Mike Tyson. This entails when I say, "Mike Tyson", according to Lycan, "my utterance...is the most recent link in a causal-historical chain of reference borrowings" (*Lycan, 53*).

Interestingly enough, there is another individual, also a well-known boxer, that has the name *Tyson*, i.e., *Tyson Fury*. What I want to highlight here is that if someone were to vaguely ask, "How many fights has Tyson lost?", the name can be mistaken for either Mike Tyson or Tyson Fury – due to the ambiguity of some names – a topic I will expand upon momentarily; but what is of greater importance is that this example supports Kripke's *causal-historical theory* in that Tyson Fury was literally named after Mike Tyson. So Tyson Fury can be argued to be a more recent link regarding the use of the name *Tyson*. It's the whole, "I got the name from somebody, who got it from somebody else..., all the way back to the naming ceremony" (*Lycan, 53*) argument. Now more on *ambiguous names* – *Tyson* being 'ambiguous'. Kripke's theory has an

easy solution for this: a name is ambiguous because said name has been given to more than a single individual. That's it. So it seems that for those of us who wish to use a certain name, we only need to have first "a correct identificatory fix on the predecessor's referent" (*Lycan, 54*), and from there, the use of the name is fair game. From Kripke's perspective then, the sense of a name is not fixed by some "backing of descriptions" (*Lycan, 54*).

It's worth noting that Kripke "does not have a worked out theory" (*Lycan, 55*), rather he has presented a "picture" (*Lycan, 55*) with the potential to become a real theory. Therefore a solution to the *puzzle of identity*, albeit one that can be considered as compatible with Kripke's direct reference view remains to be seen.

This next section will be dedicated to Stalnaker's Grice-inspired analysis of *assertions* of identity sentences. I will begin by addressing his concept of *common ground* – a necessary condition for understanding later arguments, followed by an explication of Stalnaker's "diagonal proposition" (*Clapp, 21*), which seems to be a solution to Frege's puzzle regarding sentences of identity; and then this 'analysis' will be shown to be in line with Kripke's direct reference view of how names refer. Starting with the concept of *common ground*, we can think of this as the recognized and expressed information at a time in which something like a conversation tries to arise. Perhaps another way of thinking about it is that we often depend on the *context* of an action (an expression) in order to properly understand its meaning. Here, I rely on Clapp to clarify the connection between *context* and the concept of *common ground*:

"...the common ground of a communicative action is thus the context which partially determines what is meant by the action" (*Clapp, 7*).

We can then rightly assume that Stalnaker takes the common ground for an utterance, simply as the *context* – a framework provided for the utterance to operate in.

Now what is Stalnaker’s “diagonal proposition”? To understand this, we need to first understand what a *proposition* is. Generally speaking, a proposition is a structured statement of thought– an assertion really; but then what is an *assertion*? When someone makes an assertion regarding a particular topic, they are stating a declaration that they truly mean. Consider the following example: someone expresses with force to another individual that *Aliens are closer than we think!* In response to this, the other individual states *Oh no... they are going to use their technology to probe our brains and take the information to their Galactic Leaders!* These statements are expressed in a manner that the speakers truly believe what they are saying is true. Hence, they are in the form of assertions. Stalnaker’s *common ground* can “thus be defined as... the set of propositions that are *commonly believed* among the participants at that time” (Clapp, 7). I may be getting ahead of myself here, but in a way, Stalnaker’s *common ground* sounds a lot like that of *common sense* (the actual network of thoughts and ideas, not the book). Now to get from a proposition to the “diagonal proposition”, we must introduce “the conception of propositions as sets of possible worlds” (Clapp, 9). This tweaks our understanding of the common ground, in that we are to now identify propositions with “sets of possible worlds”, making the common ground “a set of sets of possible worlds” (Clapp, 9). When commonly believed propositions intersect, Stalnaker calls the set of possible worlds “*the context set*” (Clapp, 9). This is essentially the set of worlds that are not eliminated by what participants commonly believe at a given time. So a proposition is something that highlights the different ways the world can be – it reigns supreme in some worlds of possibility and at the same time eliminates other possible worlds. It then seems that a proposition is the particular set of possible

worlds where the proposition is found to be true. Does this mean that in the possible world where the proposition is true, said proposition is *necessarily* true? Clapp provides an answer to this through defining *the universal principle*:

“For a proposition to be necessarily true is for it to be true in all possible worlds, so any proposition that is necessarily true just is *the* set of all possible worlds” (*Clapp, 14*).

Stalnaker then presents a matrix, analyzing a proposition as a set of possible worlds. This is supported by his three rules for rational thinking: (1) In some but not in all of the worlds of the context set, is an asserted proposition always true; (2) In relation to each of the worlds in the context set, an asserted utterance should express a proposition that in every possible world of the context set, has a truth-value; (3) Relative to the possible worlds in the context set, the same proposition need be expressed. With all of this, we can finally answer the question: what is the “diagonal proposition”? Essentially, it runs diagonally down the columns and rows of the given matrix, outputting a new matrix where the expressed proposition (assertion) is now true in every world, hence the proposition is the set of possible worlds, so it can be considered *necessarily true*. So in more simple terms, the “diagonal proposition” rearranges the matrix to make the proposition true in every world.

So then, have we found a solution to Frege’s identity puzzle? And if so, is it in support of Kripke’s direct reference view? It seems that Stalnaker, through the employment of his Grice-inspired analysis of *assertions* of identity sentences, has found a solution – indeed. This ‘analysis’ shows that asserted propositions like *Mike Tyson is the baddest man on the planet* and *Mike Tyson is Kid Dynamite*, once exposed to the “diagonal proposition”, can be considered not

only *true*, but *necessarily true* – it would be true in all possible worlds that Mike Tyson holds the ‘other names’ of *baddest man on the planet* and *Kid Dynamite*. Obviously, if not exposed to the “diagonal proposition” then it may not be true in all possible worlds; but ideally we only want to express asserted propositions that we believe to be true in every possible world, therefore (if my understanding is correct) becoming *common ground*.

Regarding Kripke’s direct reference view, “which Stalnaker endorses” (Clapp, 19), he would say that *Iron Mike* (another *name* for Mike Tyson) and *Kid Dynamite* “are rigid designators” (Clapp, 19). I use *Iron mike* instead of the previous *baddest man on the planet* here because it more appropriately follows the “Hesperus is Phosphorus” (Clapp, 19) argument (i.e., one example being at different times in *his* life; the other being at different times of *the* day). So then if an asserted proposition like *Kid Dynamite is Iron Mike* is true, then it is necessarily true – true in every possible world (to tie it back to Stalnaker). Therefore, through his Grice-inspired analysis of *assertions*, Stalnaker seems to present the most satisfying solution to Frege’s *puzzle of identity* – one that has been proven to be in line with Kripke’s direct reference view of how names refer.

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